Delivering History: The Story of the Mail

Target Grade Range: 3rd-5th

Overview:

Every day, a mail carrier brings pieces of history to our doors. In this lesson, students will follow the mail's story, from a tavern in colonial Boston to the letter carrier's truck today. They will learn that Savannah's post office began in 1775, before the Declaration of Independence was signed, and that W. W. Law, a Savannah letter carrier for more than forty years, was part of that story. Students will explore five kinds of mail (letters, postcards, telegrams, greeting cards, and junk mail) and discover why each one can be a primary source. They will also ask a big question: mail helps us remember the past, but what does it do to the environment, and how can we be thoughtful about it? Students will finish by playing the role of archivists who decide what to keep.

What is a Primary Source:

A primary source is something made by a person who lived through an event or time period, or something created at the time it happened. It gives us a first-hand look at the past. Letters, diaries, photographs, newspapers, maps, recordings, and objects such as tools, clothing, and stamps are all primary sources.

A secondary source is created later by someone who wasn't there, such as a textbook, an encyclopedia, or a documentary. Secondary sources help explain the past, but primary sources let us look at the past for ourselves.

A simple way to remember the difference: a photograph taken at your birthday party is a primary source. The story a friend tells you about your party a week later is a secondary source.

Primary sources are cared for in archives. An archive is a place where people called archivists collect, protect, and organize important records so that people today, and people in the future, can study them.

Video: Social Studies with The Southern Tech. "What are Primary and Secondary Sources? | How to Teach Social Studies Skills

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Tbth_A_Urd8

Mail as primary sources:

Mail is one of the best kinds of primary sources because it was made by real people at a real moment, to be sent to someone else. A piece of mail can tell us:

- **Who was involved.** The sender, the person who received it, and sometimes others who are mentioned.
- **When and where.** A postmark shows the date and the town where the mail was sent. An address shows where people lived.
- **What things cost.** The value on a stamp shows the cost of mailing at that time. Advertisements show prices for goods.
- **How people communicated.** Was it a long letter, a quick postcard, or a telegram with only a few words? Each one shows what was available and what people needed.
- **What everyday life was like.** Mail shows what people wrote about, bought, celebrated, and worried about. It gives us the stories of ordinary people, not only famous ones.

Mail also has limits. One letter is one person's view on one day. People tend to save special letters and throw away ordinary mail, so the mail that survives is not a complete picture. Historians ask: Who made this? Who was it for? Why was it saved? What is missing?

Video: The Smithsonian Institution. "A Short History of the Mail"

https://www.smithsonianmag.com/smithsonian-institution/brief-history-united-states-postal-service-180975627/

People have always needed ways to send messages. In the United States, the mail system grew along with the country. Here are some important moments:

- **1639:** A tavern in Boston becomes the first post office in the American colonies.
- **1775:** The Continental Congress names Benjamin Franklin the first postmaster general on July 26, 1775. Post offices in the colonies, including Savannah, are established under the new system that same day.
- **1847:** The first U.S. postage stamps are issued: a 5-cent stamp with Benjamin Franklin and a 10-cent stamp with George Washington.
- **1860–1861:** The Pony Express sends mail by horse and rider between Missouri and California. It ends after about eighteen months, when telegraph lines make messages faster.
- **1863:** Free home delivery of mail begins in cities.
- **1864:** The first Railway Post Office begins. Workers sort mail on a moving train.

- **1873:** The first U.S. postal cards are issued.
- **1896:** Rural Free Delivery begins, bringing mail to farms and country homes. It becomes permanent in 1902.
- **1913:** Parcel Post begins. People can now mail packages, and mail-order shopping grows.
- **1918:** Regular airmail service begins.
- **1963:** ZIP Codes are introduced to help sort mail faster.
- **1971:** The United States Postal Service begins operating in its present form.

Fun fact: In the late 1880s, a dog named Owney began riding along with the mail on trains, and he became a famous mascot of railway mail workers.

For more information: The Smithsonian Institution. "Owney."

https://postalmuseum.si.edu/owney

Mail has always moved with the newest technology: horses, stagecoaches, steamboats, trains, airplanes, and trucks. Today, people send many messages through email and phones, but the mail still delivers letters, cards, and packages to nearly every address in the country.

Savannah and the Mail:

The Savannah post office was established in July 1775, when Benjamin Franklin became postmaster general. That is before the Declaration of Independence was signed in 1776.

Savannah is also a port city, so letters often traveled in and out of the city by ship as well as by road and railroad. Later, the city's post office became a well-known landmark, and it appears on old postcards in the archives' collections.

https://vault.georgiaarchives.org/digital/collection/vg2/id/3558/rec/8

W. W. Law and the Mail:

W. W. Law worked as a letter carrier in Savannah for more than forty years. His story is part of a larger history.

Read-aloud idea: Delivering Justice: W. W. Law and the Fight for Civil Rights by Jim Haskins is an illustrated biography written for young readers.

Purchase here:
https://www.amazon.com/dp/0763625922?lv=shuf&channelId=500&plpRedirect=mhFallback

YouTube reading: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FfFQU2bfmVg

Video: WJCL. "Black History Month Profile: W. W. Law"

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gHLGfC_mt3k

- **Post office jobs were important.** In Law's time, many good jobs were closed to Black workers. Steady jobs with the Post Office helped many Black families build stable lives and helped a strong Black middle class grow.
- **Letter carriers knew their neighborhoods.** A letter carrier walks or drives the same route again and again, and gets to know the people and places along it. Many letter carriers across the South, including Law in Savannah, became leaders in the civil rights movement.
- **Law's work took courage.** In 1961, Law was fired from his postal job because of his civil rights work. National NAACP leaders and President John F. Kennedy spoke up for him, and he was hired back.
- **Law's letters are in the archives.** The letters he wrote and received show how he worked with others, and they help us remember his leadership. Types of Mail:

Letters: A letter is a written message sent to another person. Letters can be handwritten or typed, and they can be short or long. Letters often tell us the most about a person's thoughts, feelings, and plans. As a source, a letter gives us a person's own voice and details.

Postcards: A postcard is a card with a message on one side and a picture on the other, sent without an envelope. The first U.S. postal cards were issued in 1873, and postcards became very popular in the early 1900s. The pictures show us what places looked like, and the short messages tell us what people were doing. Because a postcard can be read by anyone who handles it, writers kept their messages short and open.

Telegrams: A telegram is a message sent over wires as a code of clicks and then delivered by hand. Telegrams were fast, and they were used for urgent news. They were charged by the word, so senders kept them very short. The telegraph helped end the Pony Express. As telephones became common, telegrams faded, and in 2006 the last major telegram service in the U.S. shut down. A telegram is a primary source that shows how people shared important news quickly.

Greeting cards: A greeting card is a printed card for a birthday, a holiday, a thank-you, or another special occasion, often with a handwritten note inside. The first commercial Christmas card was printed in England in 1843, and the first Christmas-themed U.S. stamp

was issued in 1962. Greeting cards show us traditions, art, and the things people celebrated.

Junk mail (advertising mail): Junk mail is mail sent to many people at once to sell something or ask for money. It includes flyers, coupons, catalogs, and offers sent to "Current Resident." It may not be popular today, but it is a real primary source. An old catalog or store flyer shows what things cost, what people wore, and what businesses wanted people to buy. In 1872, Montgomery Ward mailed one of the first mail-order catalogs, and catalogs helped people in faraway places buy goods they could not find nearby.

Video: Today I Found Out. "Mailing Children."

https://www.youtube.com/shorts/jNDxKSMrBLA

Video: Mystery Science. "How Does Mail Get Delivered?"
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0JQNL_QuQzY

Mail and the Environment:

Mail helps us stay connected and preserves history, but it also affects the environment. Students can think about the whole journey of a piece of mail.

- **Paper comes from trees.** Making paper uses wood, water, and energy. Envelopes, cards, catalogs, and packages all start as trees.
- **Mail travels.** Delivery trucks, airplanes, and trains burn fuel, and the gases released when fuel burns, called emissions, can pollute the air and add to climate change.
- **Mail ends up as waste.** Paper that is thrown away goes to a landfill. Junk mail, especially, is often thrown away without being read.
- **There are good news stories too.** Paper can be recycled, and recycled paper uses less new material. The Postal Service says it recycles large amounts of paper and cardboard and is adding electric delivery vehicles to its fleet. Mail can also be reused: envelopes can be used again, and cards can be made from scrap paper.
- **Email is not free of impact.** Email and phones use electricity too. The best choice depends on the situation, and thinking about it is what matters.

Fun thought: Law walked his route in a city neighborhood, and a person walking the mail route uses no fuel. Many routes today are driven, but some carriers still deliver on foot.

Objectives:

- Explain why mail can be a primary source, and name what different kinds of mail can tell us

- Describe important moments in the history of the mail system and how mail delivery has changed
- Explain how Savannah's post office and W. W. Law's work as a letter carrier connect to that history
- Identify and compare five types of mail: letters, postcards, telegrams, greeting cards, and junk mail
- Describe ways mail affects the environment and ways people can reduce or reuse paper
- Explain why archives keep some mail and decide what might be worth keeping

Time Required:

Note: Video times are not included in the total.

About 100 minutes in total. This lesson works well as two class sessions of about 50 minutes each, taught on the same day or on separate days.

- **Session 1:** Hook, Mail Through Time, Savannah and W. W. Law (about 50 minutes)
- **Session 2:** Types of Mail Stations, Mail and the Environment, Be the Archivist, and Closing (about 50 minutes)

Topic(s): Social Studies, local history, and Science

Standards:

Social Studies (Georgia Standards of Excellence)

- **SS4E1.f (Grade 4):** Give examples of technological advances and their effect on business in the growth of the United States, such as the steamboat, steam locomotive, and telegraph. Mail delivery is a strong example.
- **SS4H1.b (Grade 4):** Describe the influence of key individuals during the American Revolution, including Benjamin Franklin, the first postmaster general.
- **SS5H6 (Grade 5):** Describe the importance of key people, events, and developments between 1950 and 1975, including the effects of Jim Crow laws and practices (a) and the key events and people of the Civil Rights movement (b). W. W. Law offers a Georgia example from this same time.
- **SS3CG2.b (Grade 3):** Explain why it is important for citizens in a democracy to take part in public life, including staying informed, volunteering, and communicating with public officials. Writing letters is one way people communicate.

- **Social Studies Information Processing Skills (Grades 3–5):** identify and use primary and secondary sources; analyze artifacts; compare similarities and differences; draw conclusions and make generalizations.

Science (Georgia Standards of Excellence)

- **S3L2 (Grade 3):** Obtain, evaluate, and communicate information about the effects of pollution (air, land, and water) and humans on the environment, (a) including how to ask questions about sources and (b) effects and explore solutions such as conservation and recycling.

English Language Arts (Georgia Standards of Excellence)

- **ELAGSE3RI1, ELAGSE4RI1, ELAGSE5RI1 (Grades 3–5):** Use details from a text to answer questions and explain what it says.
- **ELAGSE3SL1, ELAGSE4SL1, ELAGSE5SL1 (Grades 3–5):** Take part in group discussions, listen to others, and build on their ideas.

Materials:

- A mail bag, tote bag, or large envelope for the hook
- Copies of mail from the archives, such as letters, postcards, telegrams, greeting cards, and advertisements, for each type of mail station LINK to archive examples for each type of mail. Copies are best for classroom handling so the originals stay safe.
- Examples of modern mail: a real envelope with a stamp and postmark, a postcard, a greeting card, and a few pieces of junk mail (catalogs, coupon flyers)
- Index cards or copies of the Mail Through Time cards (Student Handout 1), string or a clothesline, and clothespins or tape
- Mail Type Detective chart (Student Handout 2)
- Keep or Toss: Be the Archivist (Student Handout 3)
- Recycling bin and a bin for “reuse” (for the sorting activity)
- Pencils, markers, and sticky notes

Key Vocabulary:

- **Mail:** letters, cards, packages, and other items sent through the postal system
- **Postal service:** the organization that collects, sorts, and delivers mail
- **Postmaster general:** the person who leads the nation’s postal service
- **Postmark:** a mark from the post office that shows the date and place a letter was mailed

- **ZIP Code:** a number that helps the post office sort mail by area
- **Pony Express:** a fast mail service by horse and rider that lasted about eighteen months in 1860–1861
- **Telegram:** a message sent by wire as a code and delivered by hand
- **Correspondence:** letters written back and forth between people
- **Primary source:** something made at the time of an event or by someone who was there
- **Archive:** a place that keeps important records safe so people can study them
- **Archivist:** a person who collects, protects, and organizes records in an archive
- **Advertising mail (junk mail):** mail sent to many people at once to sell something
- **Emissions:** gases released into the air when fuel is burned
- **Recycle:** to turn used materials into new ones
- **Reuse:** to use something again instead of throwing it away
- **Civil rights:** the rights every person should have, such as being treated fairly and equally

[Suggested Program]

Introduction (10 minutes):

Hook: The Mystery Mail Bag (5 minutes)

- Carry in a mail bag filled with five items: a letter, a postcard, a copy of a telegram, a greeting card, and a piece of junk mail.
- Ask: What do you see? What kinds of mail are these? Which one would you want to keep? Which would you throw away? Which would a historian want to keep?
- Tell students they will investigate all five, and they will also learn where the mail has been, where it is going, and what it does to the planet.

What is Mail? (5 minutes)

- **Ask:** How do people send messages today? How did people send messages long ago?
- Explain the difference between primary and secondary sources, and ask: Is a piece of mail a primary source? Why?

Mail Through Time (20 minutes):

Build a Clothesline Timeline

- Hand out the Mail Through Time cards (Student Handout 1) to pairs of students. Each card has a year and an event from the history of the mail.

- Have students read their cards and work together to hang them on a string in order from earliest to latest. Ask: What do you notice? How did mail travel change? Which ways of moving mail are gone? Which are still used?
- Point out that mail changed as technology changed. The Pony Express ended because of the telegraph. Trains made mail faster. Airplanes made it faster still.
- Share the fun fact about Owney, the mail dog.

Savannah and W. W. Law on the Timeline (10 minutes)

- Add two more cards to the clothesline: "July 1775: Savannah's post office is established" and "About 1948: W. W. Law begins work as a letter carrier in Savannah."
- Show a map of Savannah and a photograph of the post office.
- **Ask:** Savannah's post office is older than the United States' independence. What might that tell us about Savannah's history?
- Share the student-friendly summary: "W. W. Law delivered mail in Savannah, Georgia, for more than forty years. In his time, post office jobs were an important way for many families to earn a steady living. Letter carriers knew their neighborhoods well. Law was also a leader who worked peacefully with others for fair treatment. He wrote and received many letters, and those letters are in the archives today."
- **Ask:** Why might a letter carrier be someone people in a neighborhood trust? How is Law's story part of the story of the mail?

Types of Mail Stations (20 minutes):

Investigate Five Kinds of Mail

- Set up five stations, one for each type of mail. At each station, place a short card that explains the type of mail (see "Types of Mail" above), plus one or two real examples or copies from the archives.
- Place students in small groups. Each group gets a Mail Type Detective chart (Student Handout 2) and spends about three or four minutes at each station.
- At each station, students look closely and write: Who sends this kind of mail, and why? What clues would a historian find? Is it a primary source?
- Walk around and ask: How do you know? What might this piece of mail not tell us?
- Share out. Ask: Which type of mail surprised you? Which would be best for learning about an everyday person's life? Why might junk mail be useful to a historian?

Mail and the Environment (15 minutes):

Follow the Journey of a Piece of Mail

- Hold up a sheet of paper, an envelope, and a catalog. **Ask:** Where did this come from? (Trees, water, energy.) How did it get here? (Trucks, planes, carriers.) Where will it go next? (A recycling bin, a landfill, or an archive.)
- Discuss how mail can affect the environment: paper from trees, fuel used to move mail, and waste when mail is thrown away.
- **Sort activity**: Give each group a small pile of mail items. Students decide whether each one should be read and kept, reused, recycled, or stopped at the source (for example, asking to be removed from a mailing list). Discuss their choices.
- **Ask:** What are some ways to use less paper? What are some good things mail does that are worth the cost?
- **Share the news**: the Postal Service says it recycles and is adding electric vehicles. Ask students how they might help.

Be the Archivist (15 minutes):

Keep or Toss?

- Explain that archives cannot keep everything. Archivists have to decide what is worth keeping, and they think about space, cost, and what the item can teach us. Keeping too much also uses paper and storage. Choosing well is a kind of care for history and for the planet.
- Give each group the Keep or Toss: Be the Archivist worksheet (Student Handout 3). Students decide whether each mail item should be kept in the archives or recycled, and explain why.
- Invite groups to share. Point out that some items could go either way, and that is what makes the work of an archivist difficult. **Ask:** What makes a piece of mail worth keeping?
- Show students a real item the archives decided to keep (Artifact Explanation Handout).

Closing (10 minutes):

Back to the Mail Bag

- Return to the mystery mail bag. **Ask:** Would you change your choices now? What clues do you notice that you missed before?
- **Exit question:** What is one thing a piece of mail can tell us about the past?

Cross-Curricular Connection:

- **English Language Arts:** Have students write a letter to a friend or relative, using the parts of a letter, and design a postcard for their own town.
- **Math:** Compare the cost of a stamp in 1847 with the cost today. Use the dates on the timeline to work out how long ago events happened, such as how many years have passed since Savannah's post office began in 1775.
- **Geography:** Use a map to trace how mail might travel from Savannah to another state by ship, train, truck, and airplane.
- **Science:** Track how much paper mail your family or class receives in a week, and discuss ways to use less.
- **Art:** Design a stamp or a postmark for your school or neighborhood (see the Postage Stamp lesson).

Critical Thinking Questions:

- How did the ways people send messages change over time? What do you think will change next?
- Why is mail a good source for learning about everyday people?
- Why might a historian want to keep a postcard or a store flyer?
- What can a telegram tell us that a letter cannot? What can a letter tell us that a telegram cannot?
- Why do you think Savannah's post office has lasted for so long?
- Why might a letter carrier like W. W. Law be a good person to know a neighborhood?
- How does mail help people share ideas and work together for change?
- How does mail affect the environment? What can we do about it?
- Which is more important: keeping history or saving paper? Can we do both?
- Is email always better for the environment than paper mail? Why or why not?

Extension Activities:

- **Mail timeline poster:** Students create an illustrated poster of the history of the mail, including Savannah and W. W. Law.
- **Interview a carrier:** Invite a letter carrier to visit and talk about a day on the route. Ask how mail has changed and what it is like to carry it in all kinds of weather.
- **Visit the post office:** Arrange a class trip to a local post office, or to Savannah's Main Post Office, to see how mail is sorted
- **Ask an archivist:** Invite an archivist to visit, or plan an archives visit, so students can see real letters and ask questions.

- **Start a class post office:** Students write letters and postcards to each other (or other classes), design stamps, and deliver them through a class mail system.
- **Reuse project:** Make greeting cards or notebooks from scrap paper and used envelopes.
- **Pair with other lessons:** Combine this lesson with the Postage Stamp lesson and the Leader on the Route lesson.

Supporting All Learners:

- **Grade 3:** Offer sentence starters ("I see…", "This tells me…", "I think a historian would keep this because…") and a word bank. Use fewer timeline cards.
- **Grade 5:** Ask students to compare two types of mail, explain which is the strongest primary source for a question, or write a short paragraph with evidence.
- **Reading support:** Provide large-print or typed copies of handwritten items, and highlight key words.
- **English learners:** Pair students with a partner, and add pictures to the vocabulary list.
- **Extra time or movement:** Let students act out the journey of a letter or draw the timeline instead of writing.

Student Handout 1: Mail Through Time Cards

Cut apart the cards, mix them up, and put them in order from earliest to latest.

1639 A tavern in Boston becomes the first post office in the American colonies.	**July 26, 1775** Benjamin Franklin is named the first postmaster general.
July 1775 Savannah's post office is established.	**1847** The first U.S. postage stamps are issued.
1860 The Pony Express begins carrying mail by horse and rider.	**1863** Free mail delivery to homes begins in cities.
1864 Mail is sorted on a moving train for the first time.	**1873** The first U.S. postal cards are issued.
1896 Rural Free Delivery begins, bringing mail to farms.	**1913** Parcel Post begins, and people can mail packages.
1918 Regular airmail service begins.	**About 1948** W. W. Law begins work as a letter carrier in Savannah.
1963 ZIP Codes are introduced.	**1971** The United States Postal Service begins operating in its present form.

Teacher key: the cards above are already in order from earliest to latest. Shuffle them before students begin.

Student Handout 2: Mail Type Detective

Name: _____ Group: _____

At each station, look closely at the mail. Write what you notice.

Type of mail	**Who sends it, and why?**	**What clues would a historian find?**	**Is it a primary source? Why?**
Letter			
Postcard			
Telegram			
Greeting card			
Junk mail (advertising mail)			

Which type of mail do you think tells us the most about everyday life? Why?

Student Handout 3: Keep or Toss? Be the Archivist

Name: _____ Group: _____

Archives cannot keep everything. Decide what you would keep and what you would recycle. Some of these could go either way, so explain your thinking.

Mail item	Keep	Recycle	Why?
A letter from a Savannah church leader planning a community meeting in the 1960s	☐	☐	
A postcard showing images from Savannah in the early 1900s	☐	☐	
A telegram announcing that a soldier is coming home	☐	☐	
A birthday card from a grandmother with a note inside	☐	☐	
A store flyer from a Broughton Street shop in the 1950s	☐	☐	
A coupon flyer that came today and is the same as 500 others	☐	☐	
A credit card offer addressed to “Current Resident”	☐	☐	
A neighbor’s letter describing a big storm in Savannah	☐	☐	

What makes a piece of mail worth keeping?

Artifact Explanation: Why Would an Archive Keep These Items?

Archive Item	Why it was kept
Diploma from a college	John Benjamin Clemmons Sr. was a math teacher and leader in Savannah who helped many people. Even though he faced unfair rules when he was young, he worked hard to finish school, teach college students at Savannah State University for 37 years, and help Black families buy homes by working with a local bank. He also supported clubs, scout groups, and community projects to make Savannah a better and fairer place for everyone.
Bottle art	An art piece made by a Savannah artist is like a time machine that helps us remember our city's history, stories, and culture. Because the artwork is actual, physical proof of how people lived and thought during a specific time in Savannah, it preserves important memories that might otherwise be lost. By saving these unique community voices, the art serves as a lasting gift that keeps our local history safe so that kids in the future can learn about it too.
Map	An old map of Savannah from the 1800s is like a treasure chest for an archive because it shows exactly how the city grew over time. Savannah was built using a special design called the Oglethorpe Plan, which is famous for its beautiful green parks called squares. This map helps history detectives, like writers, family researchers, and city planners...and you, see where old houses stood, where early roads were built, and how Savannah became a super busy town for trading cotton.
Business card	A man named G.B. Little, Sr. started the Oglethorpe Marble and Granite Company in 1907. It is the oldest family-run business in Savannah that makes stone monuments! For nearly 100 years, four generations of the same family (from great-grandparents down to grandkids) have worked out of the exact same historic workshop on East Broad Street. Together, they have built, shaped, or fixed almost every big statue you see in Savannah's beautiful parks and squares. They also carve and take care of the historic stone grave markers and family tombs in Bonaventure Cemetery, making their hard work a permanent part of the city's history.

Silver pitcher	The *USS Savannah* silver pitcher is a very special metal water jug that shows a strong friendship between the city of Savannah, Georgia, and the U.S. Navy. This pitcher and its matching silver plates and cups sailed through ocean battles during World War II. It even survived a dangerous bomb attack on its ship! Later, in 1962, the pitcher was moved to a famous new ship that was powered by nuclear energy.